Ratan had lost his heart to a German Shepherd pup he saw on a visit to TELCO in March 1984, a cuddly bundle of joy with irrepressible energy. He requested that the pup be brought to Bombay and paid first-class train carriage fare for Kumar to bring it to him.

Two weeks later, Kumar arrived in Bombay VT station along with the pup. He alighted holding the agitated, wriggling pup in both his hands, with his two bags hanging from his shoulders. It was his first visit to the city, and he knew no one there. He was expecting some staff from Ratan's office to be there at the station to receive him. He looked around for someone with a placard bearing his name. He saw no one and it made him nervous. Then he suddenly spotted a familiar man emerging from the rush-hour crowd calling his name. He could not believe his eyes—it was Ratan himself. There was no one else with him. Kumar wondered how he would be able to carry the pup, lug his bags and snake through the jostling commuters.

But Ratan quickly reached out and took both the bags from Kumar, despite the trainer's embarrassed protests. He slung them on his shoulders and told Kumar, 'You hold the pup, and I will carry your bags,' Kumar recalls some thirty-six years later. After nearly twenty minutes, they reached the parking lot. Ratan dug his hands into his pocket for his wallet to pay for the parking. He could not find it on him, and a desperate search yielded no money elsewhere on his person either. He then requested Kumar to lend him a fiver. The surprised trainer handed over the money and they drove home.

Kumar stayed in Ratan's flat for twenty-six days. He says that he ate the same food that was cooked for Ratan, who had instructed his help to make any dish that Kumar liked. Ratan was so thankful to him for having taken the trouble of bringing the pup, who was named Tito and would become his all-time favourite, that he treated Kumar like a family member.

When it was time for him to return to Jamshedpur, Ratan presented Kumar a NELCO radio, a prized possession in those days. He also packed blankets and woollen garments, manufactured by Empress Mills, for him and his family. And when he was leaving, Ratan was at the railway station to bid him goodbye. He personally placed a huge basket of fruits below Kumar's seat and said, 'Your children will enjoy this.'

Man's Best Friend